

PRIME MINISTER DEDICATES THE **MANOHAR INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT** AT MOPA TO THE NATION

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the new international airport at Mopa in North Goa on December 11, 2022, naming it in honour of Goa's beloved former four-time chief minister and former Union Defense Minister Manohar Parrikar.

"With the new Manohar International Airport at Mopa, Parrikarji's name will be etched in the memory of every person travelling through this airport," Modi said at a grand ceremony organised by GMR Goa International Airport Limited, adding that India has become the third-largest aviation market in the world.

The ceremony was graced by Governor P S Sreedharan Pillai, Chief Minister Dr Pramod Sawant, Union Minister for Civil Aviation Jyotiraditya Scindia, Union minister of State for Tourism and Ports Shripad Naik, Rajya Sabha MP Vinay Tendulkar and Pernem MLA Pravin Arlekar.

The Manohar International Airport, which is Goa's second airport after Dabolim, will have the capacity to handle 4.4 million passengers per annum (MPPA) in Phase I and this can be expanded to a saturation capacity of about 33 MPPA by the fourth phase.

The prime minister said, "India has made every possible effort to improve the ease of travel for tourists. We have increased visa-on-arrival facilities and simplified the visa process. In 70 years after India's independence, only 70 airports were built. However, in the last eight years, the government has built 72 airports in the country."

The Manohar International Airport is a testimony to the government's advancement towards aviation, tourism and economic development in the country.

The prime minister is keen on building heritage and spiritual tourism in India and promoting a new India in the 21st century.

Chief Minister Dr Sawant said, "The Manohar International Airport will stimulate economic growth in Pernem by creating around 3000 to 4000 jobs as well as self-employment opportunities for locals."

"With the inauguration of the new airport, we open the doors of progress and the growth of Goa's tourism", he added. "The new airport will help develop a cargo facility and with this, Goa's logistics sector will take off and the state will see the new light of advancement," he said.

"Dabolim airport in South Goa will remain operational even after GMR operationalises the new airport on January 5," Dr Sawant promised and continued that "international flights at Mopa are expected to start from March onwards"

He promised that with both airports functioning, the state will see an increase in tourism, income and revenue. "We need both the airports because it will help increase Goa's tourism tremendously," he said.

"The airport will boost the socio-economic development of the state," Dr Sawant said. "It has the potential of serving as a key logistics hub, directly connecting 35 domestic and 18 international destinations. Also while there was no night parking facility at Dabolim, the Manohar International Airport has provisions for it.," he added.

Dr Sawant said that he has also planned multi-modal connectivity for the airport. The six-lane road linking the national highway to the airport at Mopa will be completed by August 2023.

